

Illiquidity: the decade-long deal

Bundle Academy · Core path · Level 1 · 3 min · Source document for NotebookLM video generation

Why you can't sell startup shares like stocks, what PISCES windows change, and what they don't.

WHAT THIS VIDEO MUST LAND

By the end the viewer should be able to state the argument below in their own words. It is one argument, not a list of tips. Every number is illustrative of published ranges, not a forecast of any specific investment.

- There is no continuous market: selling needs a buyer, a price and consent.
- Seven to ten years is the honest planning horizon.
- Wind-downs and acquisitions dominate; IPOs are rare.
- PISCES windows add periodic liquidity, not on-demand liquidity.

THE ARGUMENT, IN ORDER

1 There is no sell button

Narration: Private shares have no continuous market. A buyer, a price and the company's permission all have to line up at once.

On screen: A stat visual.

Hold: about 7 seconds

2 How long money is actually tied up

Narration: From first cheque to cash back, seven to ten years is normal. Plan around that, not around the optimistic case.

On screen: A curve over time. Shape matters more than precise values.

Hold: about 8 seconds

3 The ways out, ranked by likelihood

Narration: Acquisition is the common one. Secondaries are growing. IPOs are rare, and "zombie" companies that neither die nor exit are more common than either.

On screen: A bar chart measured in % of outcomes: Failure / wind-down = 48 % of outcomes; Acquisition = 26 % of outcomes; Zombie, no exit = 18 % of outcomes; Secondary sale = 6 % of outcomes; IPO = 2 % of outcomes.

Hold: about 8 seconds

4 What PISCES changes

Narration: The UK's new private-share venue creates scheduled trading windows. Real liquidity, but periodic, permissioned, and only for participating companies.

On screen: A timeline visual.

Hold: about 8 seconds

5 The rule that follows

Narration: Only commit money you will not need for a decade. Illiquidity is the risk you feel last and regret most.

On screen: A stat visual.

Hold: about 6 seconds

THE SAME ARGUMENT IN PROSE

Public shares trade continuously because an exchange guarantees a counterparty. Private shares have nothing like that. To sell, you need someone who wants to buy that specific company at a price you both accept, and usually the company's consent to transfer the shares at all.

The practical result is a holding period measured in years. Seven to ten from first investment to any cash back is a reasonable planning assumption, and plenty of companies take longer or never get there.

Exits are not evenly distributed either. Wind-downs are the single most common outcome, acquisitions are the realistic good case, and IPOs are rare enough that planning around one is not planning. The under-discussed category is the zombie: a company that survives without ever producing an exit.

PISCES, the UK's intermittent trading venue for private shares, genuinely improves this. It creates scheduled, disclosed, permissioned windows in which existing shareholders can sell. It does not turn private equity into a liquid asset, and it only helps for companies that choose to run a window.

TONE AND CONSTRAINTS

- **Never give advice.** Describe how the asset class behaves. Do not tell the viewer what to buy, how much to invest, or that anything is a good opportunity. No "you should", no "we recommend".
- **Do not invent numbers.** Use only the figures in this document. If a figure is not here, leave it out rather than estimating one.
- **Keep the risk honest.** Losing everything is the single most likely outcome for any one early-stage company. Never soften that, and never end on a purely upbeat note that contradicts it.
- **Plain English.** UK spelling. Expand any term the first time it appears. No hype words: no "unlock", "supercharge", "game-changing", "revolutionary".
- **Calm, factual delivery.** This is an explainer, not a pitch. No urgency, no countdowns, no scarcity.
- **No specific companies.** Do not name real companies as examples, and do not imply any listing is available or recommended.

BASIS OF THE FIGURES

Illustrative timings. Secondary access varies by company, venue and share class.

Bundle is an aggregator of private-market opportunities listed on third-party venues. It holds no client money, executes no trades and gives no advice. Private-market investments are illiquid, are not covered by the FSCS, and you may lose all the money you invest. This document is educational source material, not a financial promotion.